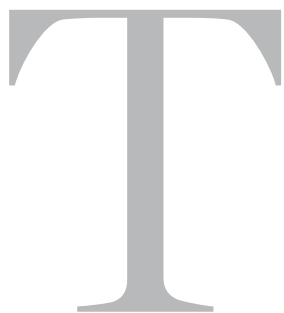


Next Phase of TN's Growth is About Creating Value Over Volume

TN's Minister for Industries S. Keerthana on how the state is preparing for the next decade of global manufacturing

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

90 |



TAMIL NADU'S INDUSTRIAL history dates to the 1950s. Since then, the state has remained at the forefront of manufacturing.

Let's look at the diversification across manufacturing segments to begin with. Be it automobiles, textiles and apparel, or auto components, Tamil Nadu is well positioned in all three. That, with a high-quality workforce, gives comfort to potential investors. Through the decades, the state has adapted to the opportunities by making the right moves, creating industrial estates and getting the best technology. All these have led to a unique model, but one that is tremendously robust.

Tamil Nadu has been the fastest-growing major state in exports over the seven years and emerged as the leader in the number of factories and total factory workers categories.

Carrying forward the state's industrial legacy is **S. Keerthana**, Minister for Industries, Government of Tamil Nadu. At 30, she is the youngest member of the state cabinet. In a chat with *Business Today*, she articulates the manufacturing vision and why Tamil Nadu is well set for every technological disruption. Edited excerpts:



What makes Tamil Nadu a preferred manufacturing destination for companies of all sizes?

Tamil Nadu's strength lies in the fact that it offers something valuable to every manufacturer, whether it is a global corporation, a fast-growing mid-sized company, or an MSME (micro, small and medium enterprise).

We have India's largest manufacturing workforce, with nearly 2.9 million people employed in factories, giving investors the confidence that they can scale operations without worrying about talent availability. Equally important is the fact that we have one of the country's deepest supplier ecosystems. Tamil Nadu has the largest number of registered MSMEs in India, accounting for nearly 15% of the total. These enterprises are not isolated businesses; they are deeply integrated into the supply chains of large manufacturers and form the backbone of our industrial economy.

Another defining strength is diversification. Tamil Nadu is a national leader in electronics exports, automobiles and auto components, and textiles and apparel. This broad industrial base makes our economy resilient and enables investors to benefit from strong cross-sector linkages.

That said, our greatest advantage is something that cannot be built overnight. Manufacturing ecosystems are created over decades. What investors find in Tamil Nadu today particularly appealing is the cumulative strength of talent, suppliers, infrastructure, policy stability and institutional capacity coming together in one place. That is why companies continue to choose Tamil Nadu—not for one advantage, but for an ecosystem that consistently enables long-term growth.



Over time, how have industrial policies helped Tamil Nadu in attracting large manufacturing investments?